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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

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Sub Region: Southern Africa

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Section Title(S): Ownership

Ownership, in the sense used here, is diminished to some extent by the obligations that kinship and friendship impose on owners to lend many of their possessions. Avoidance relatives may borrow "general use" artifacts after asking permission, but a joking relative may borrow without the formality of a request. ("General use" objects include utensils for preparing food; tools for working wood, leather, and iron; dancing rattles, and finger pianos.) The owner is not expected to relinquish possessions that he is actually using at the time, but the obligation to lend does intrude upon the degree of control that an individual has over his property.

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At the same time, obligatory lending increases the utilization of the possessions by widening the circle of users beyond the household of the owner to the whole range of borrowers. The increased efficiency of utilization allows the band to maintain the same technological level with a smaller total number of tools and utensils than [237](#) would be required if each household had recourse to only its own possessions. Two or three metalworking kits (anvil, hammer, and, perhaps, files) are sufficient for the whole band's needs. The rate of use of many other general use artifacts varies according to season; pestles and mortars, for instance, are used intensively in every household in melon season but are hardly used at all in the second half of the year until the *Boscia* berries ripen. In the slacker seasons the band can make do with a smaller number of mortars, and it is not necessary for every household to carry this heavy and bulky equipment on each migration between campsites. Instead, some households may leave their less intensively used implements behind, safely stored in the branches of trees until widespread need again arises. In the meantime the burden of migration is slightly lessened. As all possessions must be carried, it is advantageous to minimize the load and maximize the band's mobility, thus allowing a wider choice of campsite and food supply.

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